

**Improving Coordination and Communication in Donations for Disaster Relief Operations via
Studying the Impact of News Cycles**

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Abstract

In this report, humanitarian aid donations made after the earthquakes in Turkey on February 6, 2023 are examined by comparing their reflections in real-life situations and news sources. Exploring online news sources with different ideologies and perspectives and a variety of personal YouTube content creators, the research identifies key challenges of donation management in the context of emergency logistics and highlights the role of news sources in disseminating humanitarian information. Need lists shared by various NGOs, municipalities and institutions through news sources are analyzed to evaluate their compatibility with real needs and to check whether they match donors' donations.

Keywords: humanitarian aids, donation management, news content, donation packaging, need list

1 Introduction

In the early hours of February 6, 2023, southern Turkey was shaken by two significant earthquakes exceeding magnitude 7.5. These earthquakes, with their epicenter in Kahramanmaraş and often referred to as the "February 6th earthquakes" or "Kahramanmaraş earthquakes", represent a profound example of disaster. Such events are characterized by their sudden nature and cause significant damage, destruction and human distress. The February 6 earthquake affected an area where more than 13 million people live, the death toll exceeded 50,000 and the number of injured exceeded 100,000. Earthquakes caused major damage to infrastructure, including transportation and communications networks. This damage significantly hampered rescue and relief operations, with thousands of buildings destroyed, many people trapped under rubble, and many more left without shelter or basic means of livelihood. Challenges were exacerbated by harsh winter conditions, coordination complexities, and the apparent unpreparedness of both government and non-governmental organizations.

In the wake of a disaster of this magnitude, the importance of humanitarian logistics, disaster relief situations and the efficient transportation, storage and distribution of goods and materials from source to end users and meeting the needs of those affected is underlined. Caunhye et al. (2012) emphasize that aid distribution includes the provision of basic resources such as medical supplies, shelter, and other critical assistance to the affected population.[1] Simultaneously, promptly compiling lists of necessities post-earthquake through effective coordination and communication, sharing these lists to individuals beyond the affected region, and continually updating them to incorporate incoming aid and emerging shortages constitute crucial factors in humanitarian response efforts. Successfully communicating the prepared lists and aid logistics to the public through news content is essential for the success of the aid delivery process.

This research, based on a literature review on donation management in the field of disaster relief logistics, uses lists of needs and news about the sending and distribution of aid from online news sites with both right, left and center ideologies that produce content about the Kahramanmaraş earthquake. In the study, the February 6th Earthquake is considered as a case study and the content published on humanitarian aid, including donation campaigns, lists of needs, collection, packaging, transportation, and distribution of aid, from news sources covering the first month after the disaster are analyzed. Afterwards, the analysis obtained was compared with the data obtained from the donor behavior survey conducted in

the previous project, and the relationship between news sources and donors' behavior was examined.

2 Methodology

Within the framework of this research, various methodologies were used to collect comprehensive data about the needs of the people in the disaster-affected areas and the place of the aid process in news sources. The first stage involves classifying news sources that currently produce news content and have online access into three main groups: news sources with right-wing ideology, news sources with left-wing ideology, and news sources with center ideology. Apart from news sources, personal YouTube channels that produce current news content were also examined. An important factor is to choose different sources to see how news sources with different perspectives cover and present the topic under investigation.

In order to access information about the research in the selected news sources, first the main keywords related to the research topic, such as the list of needs, humanitarian aid, aid parcels, packaging and distribution of aid, were determined and research was conducted on these keywords. In addition, in order for the research to be more efficient, the research period was limited to one month after the earthquake.

Afterwards, news content specifically about the need lists was compiled and analyzed according to the keywords in the need list. It was determined which need was repeated most and compared with the data in the donation survey analysis conducted in previous periods.

Data Collection - Youtube

One of the several avenues which were used in the project was Youtube. The main reasoning behind selecting this social media platform was due to the censoring of left-leaning voices in Turkish mainstream media and left media has mostly moved to Youtube where daily broadcasts are held covering current news. These voices have also carried a large audience onto Youtube following their departure from mainstream media. In order to have a balanced perspective reflecting the news during the first month after the earthquake, Youtube was essential to this project.

The time frame of the project imposed some limitations on the selection process. The news had to be

gathered from a reliable and consistent source as well as a source that was bringing in a large viewership to ensure some impact was created by the broadcast. One of the larger channels that fit this criteria was journalist Nevşin Mengü's channel, which as of May 2024 has 656,000 subscribers.

The information from this channel was gathered according to the following steps: Selection of videos from selected time frame, collecting the transcript of each video and matching the already decided need categories to the content of the broadcast.

The categories that were used are as follows and the Turkish words used to search related topics were as follows:

- Money:
 - Para, nakit, bağış
- Winter clothes & heaters
 - Soğuk, kıyafet, battaniye, ısıtıcı
- Generator & internet
 - Elektrik, internet, bağlantı
- Food & water
 - Aç, yemek, su
- Medical supplies
 - Doktor, tıbbi yardım, malzeme
- Gas for cars & transport
 - Mazot, benzin, ulaşım
- Blood
 - Kan
- Shelter (tent) & sleeping bags
 - Çadır, konteyner, barınma, soğuk, uyku tulumu, battaniye, yorgan, yatak
- Portable bathroom
 - Seyyar tuvalet, hijyen, lavabo
- Rescue teams & machinery
 - Arama kurtarma, ekip, makine
- Hygiene products & baby care items
 - Hijyen, ped, bebek bezi, mama, anne, bebek
- Toys and stationary
 - Oyuncak, çocuk, kırtasiye, kağıt, kalem
- Kitchen products
 - Mutfak, tencere, tava, ocak

In addition to these words in specific categories, common words that mean “help”, “donation”, “need” were also searched and later categorized based on the appropriate context (yardım, bağış, ihtiyaç). Finally, the word “yok” resulted in descriptions of many lacking items which were also added to the list. [28-48]

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Data Collection – Turkish Newspapers

Data concerning the needed aid and donation was collected from mainstream newspapers of Turkey. Most of the data for this section came from either Hürriyet newspaper or Cumhuriyet newspaper with additional data from other newspapers such as Sabah, Yeni Şafak and Habertürk. Cumhuriyet is the only newspaper in the list that is left leaning while Sabah, Habertürk and Hürriyet are center right leaning. Yeni Şafak takes a more conservative Islamism approach. Data was collected with searching the words yardım (aid), bağış (donation), acil (emergency), ihtiyaç (need), 6 Şubat Depremi (February 6th Earthquake), Diyarbakır Depremi (Diyarbakır Earthquake), Kahramanmaraş Depremi (Kahramanmaraş Earthquake) then chronologically peering through the articles that came up. Upon research it became clear that most newspapers stopped publishing articles with calls for donation after the first three days and instead focused on publishing articles about donations that were already made. Only Hürriyet and Cumhuriyet continued publishing articles that contained information about which items were needed and how donations could be made. Although it is important to note that Cumhuriyet switched to asking for cash donations directly to the Cumhuriyet Vakfı which is run by the newspaper. [49-67]

Data Collection - International News

Data on the humanitarian aid needed in Turkey following the earthquake on February 6, 2023, was collected from various international and Turkish news outlets. Keywords such as “humanitarian aid,” “relief,” and “emergency supplies” were used to access established international news websites including Forbes, NBC News, and The New Humanitarian, as well as Turkish sources publishing in English, such as Daily Sabah and Turk Kızılay. The collection of information was limited to March 6, 2023. This extended period of research was critical to ensure that all requested aid items were highlighted. By continuing to research both international and local news sources beyond the initial phase of the disaster, any late reports or updates on required supplies were included. This approach helped create a comprehensive list of items that were directly called for by those affected. Initially, the international coverage focused on the immediate needs for humanitarian aid. However, ten days after the disaster, international media coverage shifted to reporting about how countries worldwide were aiding the relief efforts. News articles and publications shifted focus to detailing international support, reporting on contributions from various countries such as search and rescue teams, medical assistance, and essential supplies like food and shelter. This shift highlighted a transition in coverage from relief calls to the aftermath and recovery efforts. One aftermath that was significantly highlighted was the psychosocial impact of the earthquake which included testimonies from those directly affected by the earthquake too. [68-81]

Data Collection - Online News Outlets

Additional data on priority needs lists and aid requirements were gathered from various sources, including news outlets, government municipalities, and NGO's such as AFAD (The Disaster and Emergency Management Authority). Most notably, almost all the news outlets used the priority needs lists published by AFAD, particularly those released on approximately the 8th and 17th of February 2023. This indicates that there were no other sources for the news outlets. Relying only on one list, like the ones from AFAD, has some problems. Different communities of people might have unique needs not mentioned in a single list and the earthquake affected 11 cities so the needs could vary significantly. Also, only two lists might not reflect changing priorities over time. To gather the data the web was searched using the keywords "yardım listesi"(aid list), "ihtiyaç listesi"(need list), "6 Şubat depremi"(February 6th earthquake) and "deprem ihtiyaçları"(earthquake needs). The search was further done by restricting the dates to get relevant information within the specific time, one month after the earthquake in our case, making the search process easier. However, with time there was a noticeable decline in the frequency of earthquake related news, with fewer updates and reports being published each day. This diminishing coverage showed the shifting focus of media attention away from the immediate aftermath of the earthquakes, potentially impacting public awareness and ongoing relief efforts. [2-27]

3 Data Analysis

The data from all sources were gathered onto an excel sheet which carried the predetermined categories. All project participants entered their sources and the date of the news they had found as well as the link to it. On the right-hand side of the excel chart exists a binary value form to fill about the news piece which carries information about the related category of the news. Figure 1 shows the method of data collection.

SOURCE	DATE	DONATION TYPE	VALUE
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	money	1.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	winter clothes & heaters	1.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	generator & internet	0.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	food & water	1.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	medical supplies	0.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	gas for cars & transport	0.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	blood	0.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	shelter (tent) & sleeping bags	0.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	portable bathroom	0.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	rescue teams & machinery	0.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	hygiene products & baby care items	1.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	toys and stationary	0.00
International News / Engli	09/02/2023	kitchen products	0.00

Figure 1 - Content form on the data sheet

From this chart, a pivot table was created to display the data according to date and category.

Trends

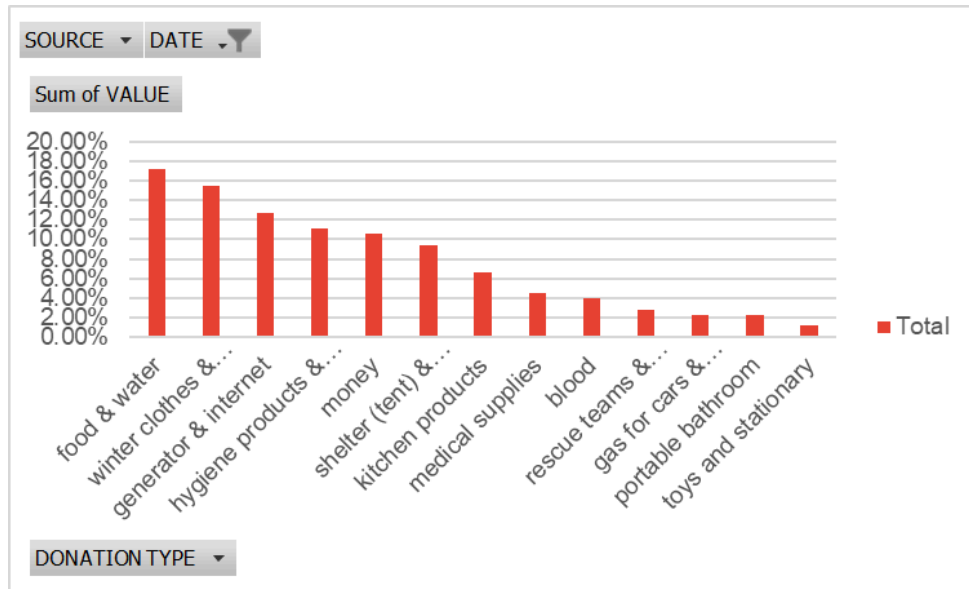


Figure 2 - Results from the first month after earthquake, mentions to each category given as a percentage of total results

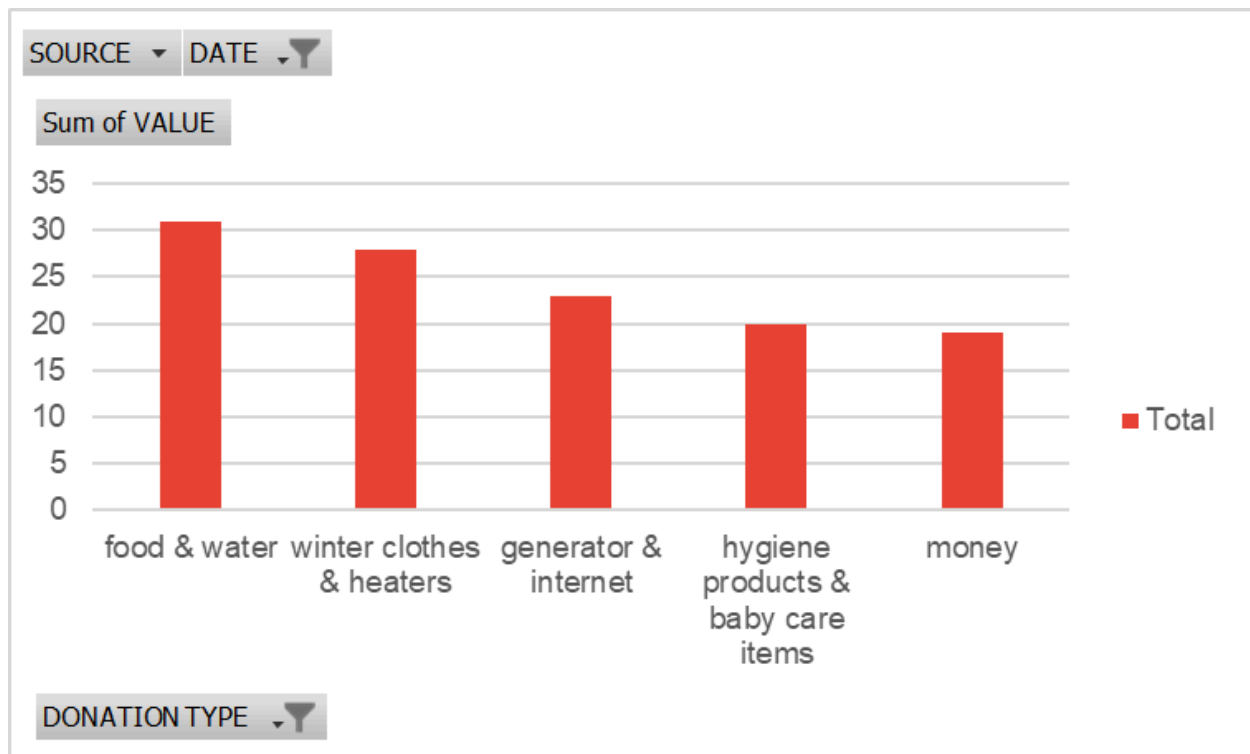


Figure 3 - Top 5 categories of need on the first week after earthquake



Figure 4 - Top 5 categories of need on the second week after earthquake

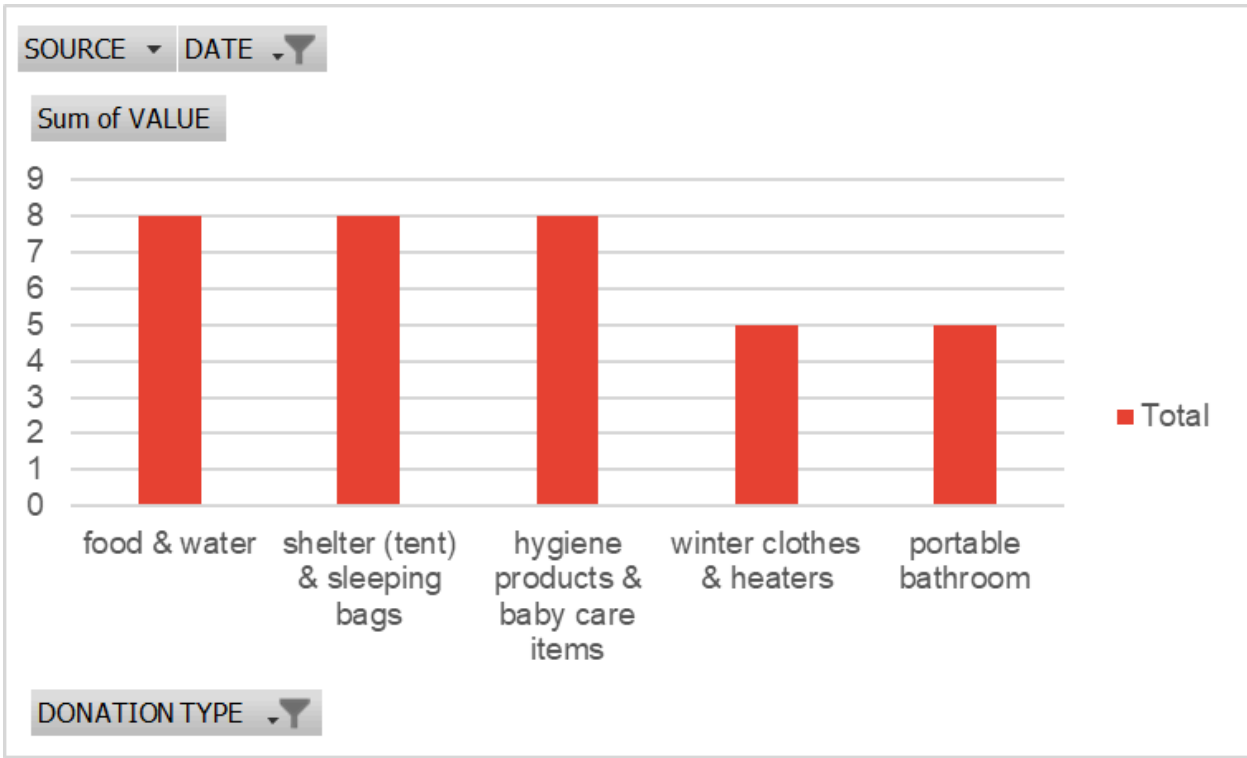


Figure 5 - Top 5 categories of need on the third week after earthquake

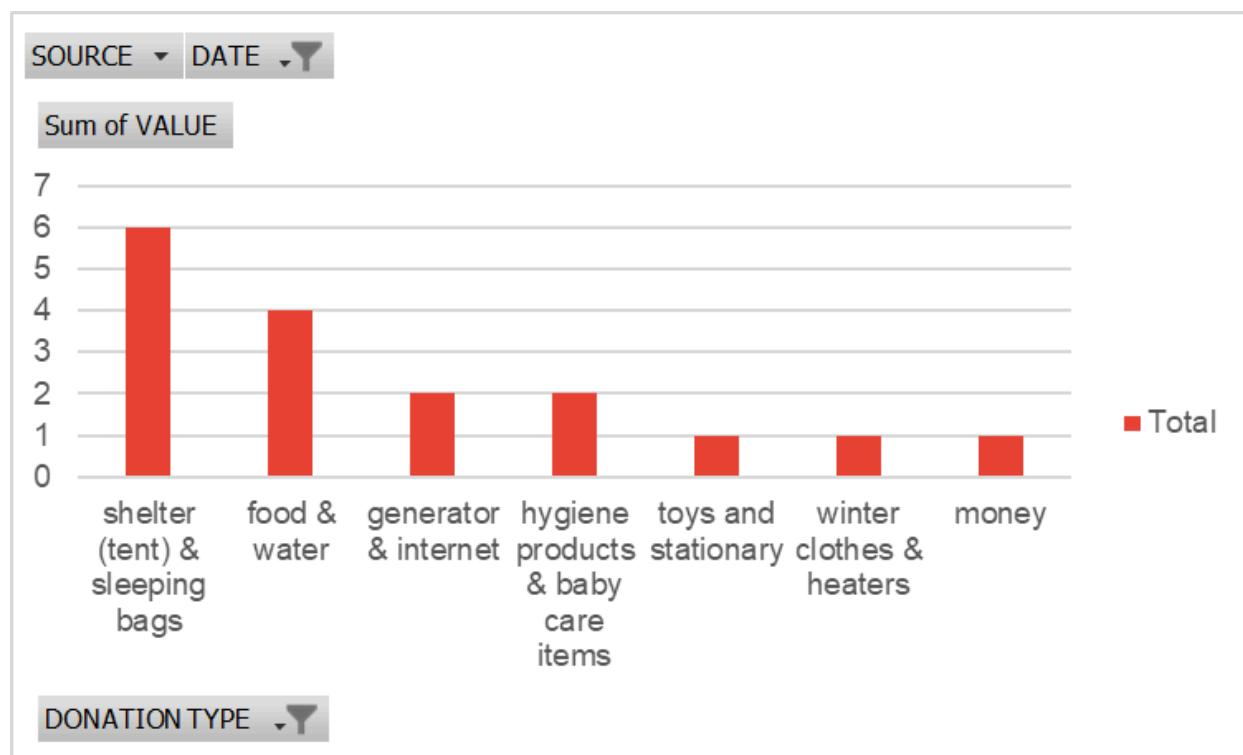


Figure 6 - Top 5 categories of need on the fourth week after earthquake

Analysis of Figures 2-6

These figures highlight the change that has occurred week by week after the earthquake by displaying the total and Top 5 for each week for the selected coverage duration of the project.

The shift from food and water in the first place to Shelter in the last week is significant. This may be due to access to better food in the region after three weeks or the severity of the housing need.

The need for winter clothing also dropped in importance, winter clothing and heaters were the second most asked item in the first week after following the earthquake but by the fourth week it had declined to being fifth on the list, which may be linked to the over donation of clothing which was reported by many news channels. This was due to many people donating their second hand clothing. It is also seen hygiene and baby products raised in importance throughout the second and third weeks after the earthquake.

There is also a decrease in the number of news reporting on the needs from the earthquake area in the later weeks, as the number of news have significantly dropped.

It is also important to note many news channels used the same donation need list distributed by AFAD.



Figure 7 - Progress of the need for winter clothes & heaters

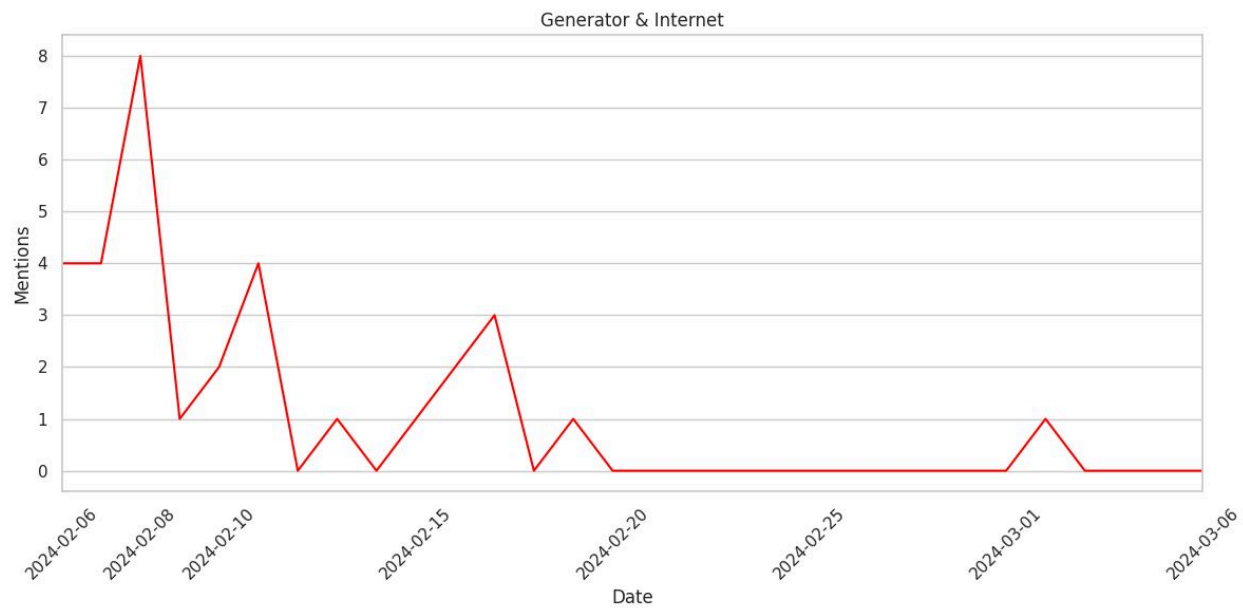


Figure 8 - Progress of the need for generator & internet

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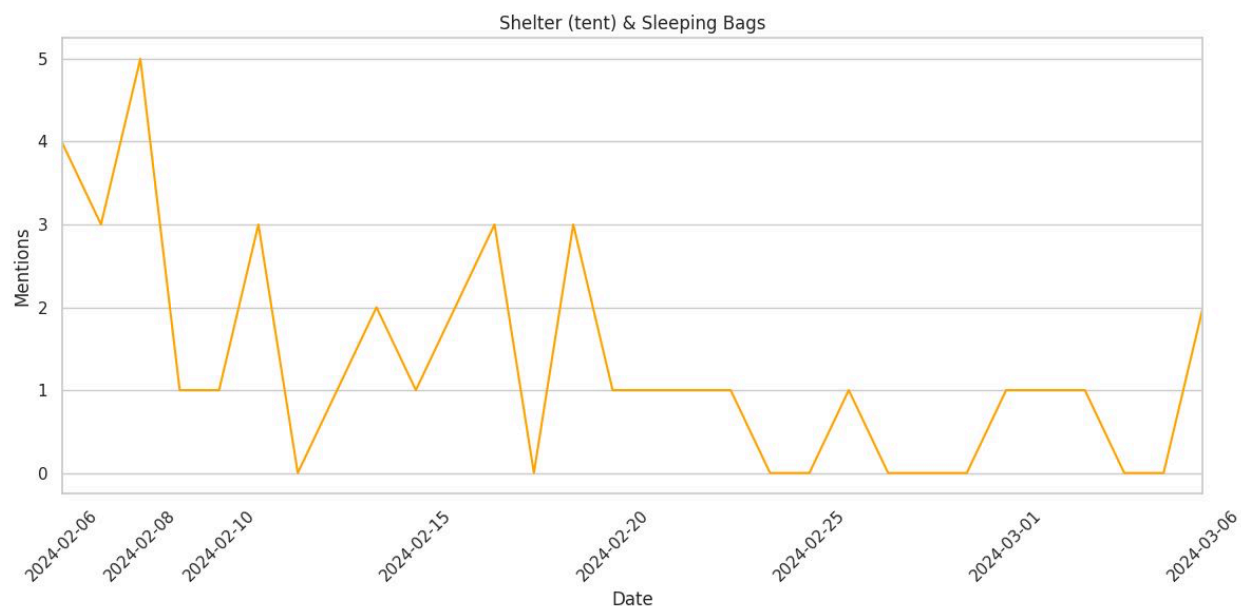


Figure 9 - Progress of the need for shelter (tent) & sleeping bags

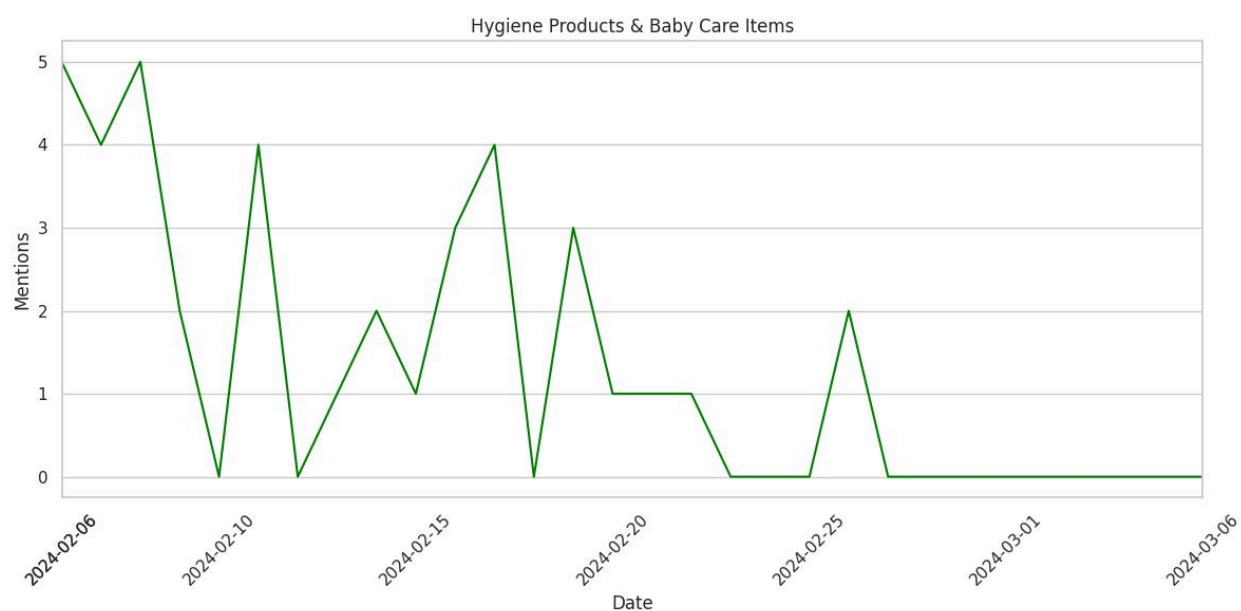


Figure 10 - Progress of the need for hygiene products & baby care items

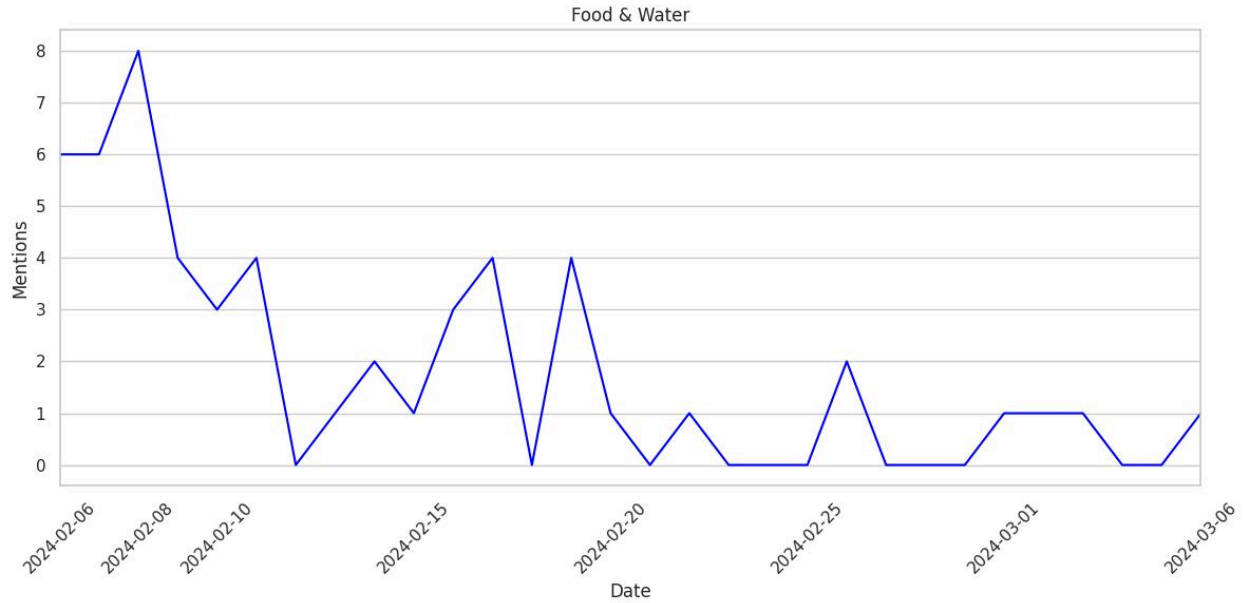


Figure 11 - Progress of the need for food & water

Analysis of Figures 7-11

It should be noted that the drop that happens to 0 at every graph on the 18th is a consequence of not finding any data for the said date.

Figure 7 shows the progress of how the need for winter clothes and heaters changed throughout the 6th of February 2023 and 5th of March 2023. It can be seen that the need for winter clothes and heaters are highest during the early days following the earthquake and it fluctuates until hitting zero. It can be observed that the second peak on the 17th is followed by the third peak on the 19th. The need for winter clothes and heaters flat lines at zero after some time.

Figure 8 graphs the evolution of the need for generators and the internet. This graph is similar to figure 7 as it also peaks around the early days following the earthquake and fluctuates until hitting zero. Its second highest value happens at the 10th of February with the need for the items equaling 4. The need for these items flat lines at zero after some time.

Figure 9 shows the evolution of the need for shelters & sleeping bags. It can be observed that the call for shelter and sleeping bags also peaks at the days following the earthquake. However, this graph is different from the previous two as it fluctuates until the end of the observing period. Even though at certain dates

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the call for the items is zero. The need for shelter and sleeping bags is constant until the end of the observing period. The peak is on the 8th of February while the second peak is on the 10th, 17th and 19th of February.

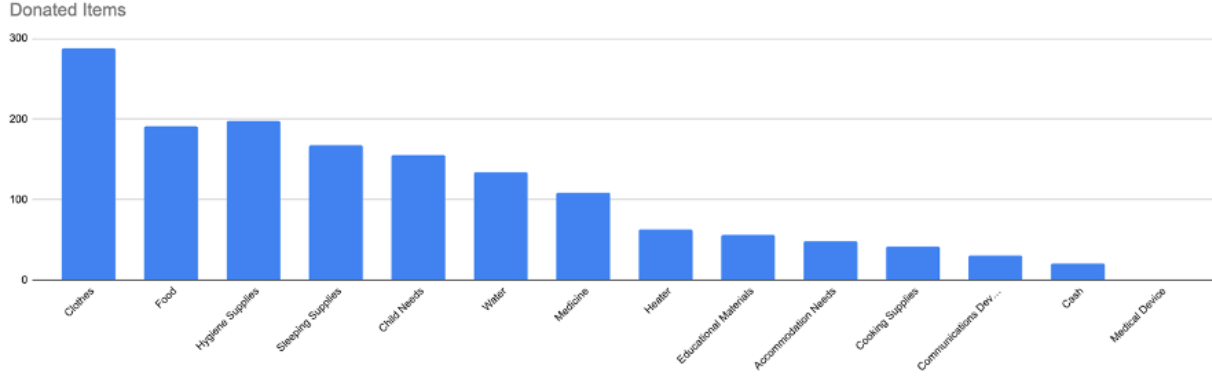
Figure 10 depicts the progress of the need for hygiene products and baby care items. The demand for these items are at its highest during the 6th and 8th of February. After those dates, it fluctuates until hitting the second highest value on the 10th and 15th of February. The demand for these products freezes at zero after the 27th.

Figure 11 depicts the progress for the demand for food and water. This item also hits its peak at the 8th of February and fluctuates throughout the month never constantly staying in zero. Its second highest value, which is 4, happens on the 11th, 17th and 19th of February.

The pattern that emerges is that for the most mentioned five items: winter clothes & heaters, generator & internet, shelter & sleeping tents, hygiene & baby care items, food & water the demand is at its highest around the first three days then it declines for some days until the demand reemerges around the 10th-11th or the 17th-19th. Afterwards the demand fluctuates around 0 and 2 but never gets as high as it does during the first two weeks.

3.1 Comparison With Donor Survey

We compared the data in this study with the data we obtained as a result of the surveys we conducted with donors in the previous period. For the most part, the needs announced by news sources coincide with the needs donated by donors. Clothes, hygiene supplies and food were among the top five in both surveys. However, other child needs and sleeping supplies, which are in the top five in the donor survey, are ranked later in news data.



4 Conclusion

In conclusion, researching donation-related news in disaster relief logistics and donation management research in the context of large-scale earthquakes provides valuable information to observe how much the donated aid matches the expressed needs by the media. This study shows that news sources and social media are important communication sources in devastating disasters, especially in providing necessary materials. When the data obtained from donor surveys and news sources were compared, it was observed that they mostly overlapped. This observation tells us that the news conveys largely accurate data to the public.

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